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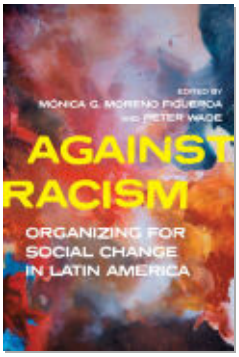

Published by University of Pittsburgh Press

Against Racism: Organizing for Social Change in Latin America.
University of Pittsburgh Press, 2022.
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CHAPTER 1

THE FORMATION OF MESTIZO NATIONS

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Mestizaje has figured as an obligatory point of reference in the national narratives of each country in a variety of ways. Practices and ideologies of mestizaje have established the terrain that anti-racist strategies must traverse, with obstacles of denial, minimization, and delegitimation. In this chapter we adopt the nation as the conceptual frame for a comparative approach that foregrounds national contexts of anti-racism, but it is important to balance this with the relational approach taken in subsequent chapters, which address themes common to all four countries.

The same relational perspective is relevant here too, insofar as the four countries share similar colonial histories, in which Iberian conquerors exploited native and enslaved African labor while according intermediate status to large numbers of mestizo offspring within a patriarchal and racial hierarchy, which was structured by concepts of relative "purity of blood" (Hering Torres, Martínez, and Nirenberg 2012).[1] These colonial dynamics created a so-called caste society, in which social strata were differentiated by the perceived degree of genealogical and social proximity relative to three polar positions: *indio* and *esclavo/negro* at the bottom and *blanco* at the top. Especially in the mestizo middle strata, attributions and claims of status and degree of mixedness were flexible and subjective enough to allow tactical maneuvering for individuals. The possibility of successive mixings over several generations also enabled indios, negros, and dark-skinned mestizos to create for their offspring the possibility of overcoming the limits of their parents' racialized condition (Mörner 1967; Wade 2010b).

This shared colonial legacy was regionally differentiated by economic, demographic, geographical, and political factors, meaning that mestizaje as a practice and an ideology—and allied formations of racism and challenges to it—developed in distinctive ways in each postcolonial country. For example, Brazil imported ten times as many enslaved Africans as all the mainland Spanish American colonies (Eltis and Richardson 2010, 202–3), and in late colonial Brazil slaves were still nearly 40 percent of the total population, while in Mexico the entire Black and *mulato* ("mulatto") population was about 5 percent. In contrast, the Indigenous population of late colonial Mexico was about 70 percent of the total, but in Brazil it was less than 6 percent (Alden 1987; Carrera 2003). Another major demographic factor was that, between 1880 and 1930, Brazil received more than four million European immigrants, second only to Argentina's six million and vastly more than any other Latin American country (Sánchez Alonso 2010).

Alongside these variations, a shared history is evident from the fact that we are able to use a common narrative structure for accounts of the four countries. For each one, it is possible to identify a national narrative of mestizo identity and then trace its destabilization by challenges from below and by the turn to multiculturalism of the 1990s. Finally, in all four there has been some enactment of anti-racist legislation and policies.

NARRATIVES OF MESTIZAJE AND RACIAL FORMATION IN MEXICO

In colonial Mexico, as elsewhere in Latin America, processes of mixture created a certain permeability and porosity of racial boundaries. However, this did not mean that racial hierarchies disappeared; they remained the benchmark for the practices and policies of mestizaje in the postcolonial period. With independence in 1810, the colonial "Republic of Indians" disappeared in 1812, meaning Indigenous peoples lost the political, social, and economic control they had enjoyed under a colonial regime that created a nominally separate set of institutions and laws for them. Slavery was abolished in 1821, and as the free Black population integrated into mestizo society, the boundaries of the *negro* category became increasingly blurred. Ideas of equality, freedom, and private property motivated the actions of both liberals and conservatives in their efforts to govern the country. José María Luis Mora (1794–1850), a founder of liberal thought in Mexico, considered that the privileged status of Indigenous people in the colonial regime made them unable to carry out the "social transactions of life" (Mora 1950, 63). For Mora, the indio of independent Mexico had to become, first of all, a citizen: "In their current state, and until they undergo considerable changes, [the indios] cannot reach the degree of civilization and culture of the Euro-

peans, nor remain as equals in a society formed by the two social groups" (1950, 77). Indigenous people were considered a major obstacle to Mexico's progress. This view culminated in the Lerdo Law (1856), which classified Indigenous communities, the church, and town halls as "corporations" and legally prohibited them from owning land (Brading 1993, 106).

Under the new liberal state, Indigenous peoples were subjected to a war of attrition: "When Mexico gained its independence from Spain in the early nineteenth century, it is estimated that approximately 40 per cent of all land suited for agriculture in the central and southern parts of the country belonged to communal villages. When [Porfirio] Díaz fell in 1911, only 5 per cent remained in their hands. Over 90 per cent of Mexico's peasants became landless" (Katz 1986, 48). During the period 1840–1860, forty-four rebellions erupted, compared to the eight rebellions recorded during the previous twenty years (Florescano 1996, 376). Although the main claims of these rebellions were land and political autonomy, elites defined these uprisings as racial wars (so-called caste wars) and presented them as a battle between civilization and barbarism. The press and public opinion were permeated by racial fear. A consequence of this was a preoccupation with changing the demography and culture of the country by attracting settlers from Europe, who were supposed to modernize the nation, help to integrate Indigenous people, and guarantee the elimination of "castes" (Florescano 1996; Hale 1968).

These new ideas helped to establish the mestizos, particularly in the growing cities. These people, among whom were ranchers, small businessmen, and mine and industry workers, found the principle of communal landownership unattractive and echoed the liberal call for equity, small property ownership, and local power (Brading 1993, 138). For *criollo* elites, the mestizo became a desirable ally in countering the presence of Indigenous people in the Mexican population.[2] The loss of almost half of Mexico's territory in the war with the United States (1846–1848) and the French invasion (1861–1867) consolidated the idea of mestizaje as a nationalist symbol, used to create a sense of unity in a Mexican society divided by many years of conflict (Brading 1993, 141).

In the late nineteenth century, as a centralized state was consolidated, a vision of the nation as a cultural, racial, and ethnic unit gained acceptance. The state increasingly promoted mestizaje, with policies encouraging education, colonization, and the privatization of Indigenous territories. Vicente Riva Palacio, in 1884, articulated the connections between mestizaje and Mexicanness in racial terms. Riva Palacio thought the mestizo was a superior product of the evolutionary process, and he questioned the accepted equation of purity with superiority and of mixture with inferiority. For him, mestizaje was no longer a path to whiteness but an end in itself. The

mestizo, Riva Palacio argued, had "accumulated virtues and vices of the various races and, multiplying over time, acquired the indisputable right to autonomy, forming a new nationality in the territory" (Riva Palacio 1884, 471).

There were more pessimistic appraisals of the national character. For example, Justo Sierra (1848–1912), secretary of education, declared that "the nation carries an impoverished blood in its veins," producing skepticism, lack of energy, resistance to useful ideas, and premature aging. This condition, he argued in an 1878 newspaper article, could be corrected only with "large amounts of iron, in the form of railroads, and large doses of strong blood, in the form of immigration" (Sierra 1980, 193–94). However, government projects of mestizaje were not enough to compensate for the inequality generated by the various political and social conflicts that eventually led the country to the violence of the Mexican Revolution (1910–1920).

After the Revolution, nineteenth-century ideas of mestizaje were reworked to respond to new social dynamics. The anthropologist Manuel Gamio managed to articulate prerevolutionary liberal ideals with the new demands of the postrevolutionary society, combining concerns for national unity and modernization and including new social actors, many of them peasants and Indigenous people. Gamio and his fellow thinkers agreed on the need to build a mestizo nation and to boost the racial evolution of Indigenous people through their assimilation to the more evolved mestizos (Gamio 1916; Saldívar 2014; Walsh 2004). Under this reworked ideology, national identity was consolidated, Indigenous policy based on assimilation was promoted, and the imaginary of a nation without a Black population was extended (Knight 1990). The ideology promoted the idea of equality, while maintaining an economy based on deep inequality and enacting differential development policies that created unequal regions (the whiter north, the mestizo center, and the Indigenous south).

The ideology also involved the persistent denial among academics and politicians of racial hierarchies and racist practices. With the support of the 1950 UNESCO declaration on race, which suggested replacing the concept of race with that of "ethnic group," ethnicity and culture became more attractive concepts to explain social relations in Mexico. For example, Gonzalo Aguirre Beltrán contrasted the situations of Black and Indigenous people in Mexico. The former "did not find major obstacles to integration into national society as soon as legal bases were established; there was no discrimination against them." In contrast, "the Indian, for whom there was legal equality, is still segregated today, forming multiple ethnic minorities and plural cultures" (Aguirre Beltrán 1969, 54). In Mexico, "cultural differences are much more important than racial distinctions as mechanisms that hinder the integration of the ethnic groups into the national society"

(Aguirre Beltrán 1989, 288). Mestizaje, he concluded, was the natural solution to the problem: in order to end discrimination against Indigenous people, it was necessary to create national ethnic unity, which can "only be obtained with the process of gradual and irreversible mestizaje" (Aguirre Beltrán 1969, 63).

THE CRISIS OF THE MESTIZO NATION IN MEXICO

By the time Aguirre Beltrán published his 1969 article, a new generation of anthropologists were denouncing the devastating impact on Indigenous communities of the assimilation and national incorporation ("deindianization") promoted by state policies of *indigenismo* and an older generation of Mexican anthropologists (Warman et al. 1970).[3] These younger anthropologists saw the domination of Indigenous peoples by the mestizo state as a form of "internal colonialism" (González Casanova 1965), in which colonial structures persisted. One exponent, Guillermo Bonfil Batalla, talked in terms of a "Western project of imaginary Mexico," which had always excluded and denied the "deep Mexico" of Mesoamerican civilization, with "no place for a convergence of civilizations that would . . . give rise to a new project" (Bonfil Batalla 1989, 10). Nevertheless, this idea of a deep Mexico focused on the inheritance (and persistence) of colonial structures as the reason for the continuing subordination of the natives, thus centering attention on the past instead of recognizing that domination persisted because it was favorable to the capitalist accumulation promoted by the liberal state. The critique thus left unchallenged the dominant postrevolutionary narrative of mestizaje.

THE CONSTRUCTION OF ANTI-RACIST POLICIES IN MEXICO

At the end of the 1980s, a profound economic crisis and challenges to the legitimacy of the revolutionary project led to a series of constitutional changes that recognized the political and cultural plurality of the country. Debates around the quincentenary of 1992 generated new perspectives on the origins of Mexico, which ranged from positions promoting a "meeting of two worlds" to more radical positions that spoke of slavery and genocide or that questioned the idea of only two worlds (Chorba 2007). In the government of Carlos Salinas de Gortari (1988–1994), plurality, justice, and democracy were cited as founding principles that would prepare Mexico for the future. In this context, the Salinas government signed the International Labour Organization's Convention 169 in 1989 and reformed the consti-

tution in 1992, officially recognizing Mexico as a multicultural nation and penalizing discrimination based on language and gender. During this time the Black population became more institutionally visible as a result of initiatives to recognize the influence of "the third root" in regional culture (Hoffmann 2006; Vaughn 2005).

These multiculturalist measures went alongside the introduction of neoliberal policies that implied the abandonment of revolutionary promises of redistribution and equity, to be replaced with ideas of participation, free competitive markets, and diversity. For the revolutionary state, mestizaje was the promise of inclusion and social justice. Under the neoliberal state of the late twentieth century, diversity and pluralism represented the promise of equality and democratic participation as part of social competence.

The irruption of the Zapatista Indigenous movement in 1994 showed that the country's multiculturalism was not enough to dismantle the homogenizing mestizaje project. The uprising changed the relationship between the state and Indigenous peoples, and the myth of victimized and submissive Indigenous peoples was challenged by images of Indigenous people as political actors with economic and social agendas, which demonstrated the failure of the inclusive promises of Revolutionary mestizaje. Assimilationist indigenist policies were replaced by legal frameworks recognizing the cultural rights of Indigenous peoples and by an intercultural education system. The early twenty-first century has been marked by the greater visibility of ethnic diversity and the identity recognition politics of Indigenous and Black groups that demanded greater political control and recognition. However, as with old-style indigenismo, ethnic difference remains the focus of state policy (Hernández, Paz, and Sierra 2004; Saldívar 2006, 2018). Meanwhile, policies of social justice have been displaced by policies focused on vulnerable populations: the racial-ethnic specificity of Indigenous populations (and more recently Black populations) is constructed as a condition of their vulnerability (Saldívar and Walsh 2015).

The instrumentalization of Indigenous and Black identities to serve as a mechanism to access benefits and services has occurred alongside a trend to make inequality visible through statistics that take account of ethnic and racial difference. This has led to a growing discussion of racism in Mexico, with discrimination based on skin color and racial identity being considered in addition to discrimination based on ethnicity. However, the recognition of racism has been limited by the reluctance to use racial categories such as white, mestizo, and Black, invoking the same arguments as were used in the mid-twentieth century. This debate has permeated discussions about the inclusion of the Black population in the 2020 census, where the use of the word "Black" has been questioned (mainly by mestizo academics), with the proposal that the appropriate term should be "Afro-Mexican"

or "Afro-descendant," since these do not have racial (colonial) connotations but, rather, refer to common origins and a cultural identity. Resistance is greater when it is suggested that using the categories mestizo and white can help explain how ethnic-racial inequality is reproduced in practice, as was evident in the INTEGRA Network's statement about the results of the 2016 national intergenerational social mobility survey carried out by the National Institute of Statistics and Geography, where racial categories were used.[4] The statement argued that the use of these categories "preserves the beliefs that races exist, and it converts ethnic, cultural and physiognomic differences of human groups into races" (Red INTEGRA 2017).[5] This resistance to talking about racism using racial categories resonates with the characteristic precepts of Revolutionary "raceless" mestizaje by demobilizing and limiting discussions about racism and anti-racist actions.

Together with the persistence of the Revolutionary ideology of mestizaje, the ways in which the issue of racial inequality has been tackled by neoliberal multicultural policies have also been influential. On the one hand, there is the rights perspective, where the emphasis is on the restitution of rights that have been historically denied (e.g., to Indigenous and Black people or to women). This perspective displaces a deeper recognition that racial inequality is not only due to lack of rights, the restitution of which is therefore not the solution. On the other hand, also inadequate is an individualistic and behavioral perspective proposing that the problem of racism can be solved with changes in attitude (promoting recognition and tolerance of the other) and nondiscrimination policies that regulate relations between individuals, without taking account of deeper structural issues.

BRAZIL, A MESTIZO NATION?

Brazil has often been seen from a European and North American perspective as a quintessentially mixed nation, and although it certainly has a very mixed population, for the country's elites the question of a mestizo national identity has not been straightforward. Modern Brazil began in 1841, with the reign of Emperor Pedro II, which laid the foundations for a Brazilian national culture, bringing to Rio de Janeiro young European artists and scientists who, together with the Brazilian elite, defined and symbolically represented the nation's future. In Brazil, French writers and journalists in particular were influential in shaping the idea of the *nation* as an entity that subsumed *race* and *people* to create a sense of historical and political belonging, built by culture and civilization (Schwarcz 1993). In contrast, other observers highlighted the fact that the "races" that made up the Brazilian people involved not only various European peoples, as in France or Britain, but peoples of diverse continental origins. In this usage, "race" could have

a stronger meaning, defined by European imperialism and colonialism as peoples not just of different civilizations and cultures but of different essential origins (Arendt 1951).

Two versions of Brazilian thinking about race and nation are well known. The first appeared at the end of the nineteenth century, at the height of the impact of scientific racism on Brazil (Skidmore 1974). This theory of whitening asserted the dominance of white racial qualities over others and proposed that the mixing of races in Brazil would eventually lead to the formation of a new white race. At this point, the idea of a mestizo nation began to take shape—but mestizo in the strict sense of the cross-breeding of peoples, not the emergence of a national meta-race.

The second variant appeared in the second decade of the twentieth century, and its name, "racial democracy," became more popularized than its ideological content. For the São Paulo modernists of the 1920s, the leadership of the white race was still a necessary condition to prevent democracy from becoming anarchy. As a result they did not emphasize *mestiçagem* (mixture) very much. However, this version, due mainly to São Paulo's isolationist tendencies, was superseded in the 1940s by Gilberto Freyre's idea of "ethnic democracy," which was popularized as racial democracy by Arthur Ramos and was quickly accepted by foreign writers as a key characteristic of the Brazilian nation (Guimarães 2007). In this version, racial democracy both enabled and was the result of the mixing of races, eventually leading to the formation of a *moreno* (brown) meta-race.

The chronological shift suggested by these two variants is too simple, however, as can be seen by comparing different ways in which "white" was defined in the context of ideas about mestiçagem. The idea of mestiçagem could be both linked and not linked to the ideal of whitening. On the one hand, when whiteness was considered in terms of civilization and culture, diverse racialized phenotypical characteristics could be encompassed in the category *branco* and it made no sense to speak of mestizos as a specific racial group. This is how we should understand the writer Joaquim Nabuco's famous letter to his colleague José Veríssimo in 1908 after the death of Machado de Assis. Veríssimo had described Machado as *mulato* and Nabuco took issue with this: "I would not have called him a mulatto and I think nothing could hurt him more. . . . For me Machado was a white man and I think that was the way he saw himself; if there was any foreign blood, it did not alter his perfect Caucasian character" (Massa 1971, 46). It is this concept of white and whitening that was rooted in areas of early Portuguese colonization, such as the Northeast, Rio de Janeiro, and Minas Gerais. It was recorded in Bahia by anthropologists such as Thales de Azevedo (1955) and Harry Hutchinson (1952) when they highlighted the use of terms such as *branco fino* (fine white—that is, perceived to have European features)

and *branco da terra* (white of the land—that is, perceived as having a darker complexion and some *mulato* features).

On the other hand, a different conception of whiteness emerged from the great European immigration when, between about 1870 and 1930, the country received over four million white Europeans, who concentrated in the most economically dynamic regions of the country, the states of Rio de Janeiro and São Paulo and the southern states of Paraná, Santa Catarina, and Rio Grande do Sul. In these southern areas, *branco* was defined almost exclusively by skin color, eventually being applied only to European immigrants. Brazilians descended from old families were, in this view, considered *mulatos* or even simply "Brazilians," insofar as ethnic labels (Germans, Poles, Italians, Spaniards, etc.) were at first stronger than a national sense of belonging. Many authors highlight the version of whitening that was characteristic of the zones of original Portuguese colonization and assume that the ideal of a mestizo nation was widely accepted by Brazilian elites. But this was not true for the southern states of Brazil, where the country's elites consciously used European immigration as a whitening instrument (Skidmore 1974). It is worth remembering here the views of the São Paulo modernist writer Paulo Duarte, who, reacting to Freyre's idea of mestiçagem, wrote in the main regional newspaper, *Estado de São Paulo*: "One thing exists and will continue to exist with complete clarity: the deliberation arrived at by a unanimous consensus of clear-thinking Brazilians: Brazil wants to be a white country and not a black country. Research that seeks to know whether the black is intellectually or morally inferior to the white, or the Indian, or whether the white or the Indian is less primitive or more advanced than the black is not relevant here. What prevails is the Brazilian decision to be a white country and nothing else. And this purpose, solid, unshakable, exists and is reality" (Duarte 1947, 5).

In any case, whether in the South or the Northeast, the ruling classes in Brazil defined themselves as white, even when they were the product of racial mixing. In contrast to twentieth-century Mexico and, to a lesser extent, Ecuador and Colombia, the term "mestizo" did not define a group that identified and led the nation. The Brazilian mestizo nation would become white as a result of racial mixture.

Relevant here is the distinction made by Black anthropologist Kabengele Munanga (1999, 108) between mestiçagem as a process of mixing culturally and phenotypically distinct populations and mestiçagem as a sociopolitical process of identity formation. In Brazil, mestiçagem did not result in the formation of an ethnically distinct group of mestizos, as it did in Mexico. Colonial designations persisted as a form of official classification in terms of color or ethnicity—white, brown, black, yellow (*amarelo*), and Indigenous. And if the term *moreno*, closer to mestizo, became widespread

in popular usage in the 1970s (Freyre 1985; Harris et al. 1993), it was never officially recognized by the state, though it did appear occasionally in the postwar years in some public statistics. In other words, while national ideologies of mestizaje were shaped by ideals of whitening in Colombia and Ecuador and even Mexico, in Brazil the version of mestiçagem that leads to whitening, as an ideal and discursive practice, managed to surpass the project of mestiçagem as a new national identity.

THE CRISIS OF BRAZIL'S MESTIZO NATION IN THE 1980S

The term "racial democracy" has always had an uncertain status in Brazil. Inspired by Freyre, some people associated it with mestiçagem when seen as a form of social ascension and assimilation. Others—mainly those involved in the Black mobilizations of the 1950s and 1960s—used it in public discourse to name an ideal of racial equality and democracy (Guimarães and Macedo 2008).

Two decades of military rule from 1964 to 1984 changed these ambivalent meanings in important ways. On the one hand, the military governments decided to make the narrative of the mestizo nation and racial democracy the official story of the nation. A telling expression of this was the suspension of a color question in the 1970 census. On the other hand, Black organizations began to denounce the narratives of mestiçagem and racial democracy, equating them with narratives of white supremacy and the ethnocide and genocide of Black people (Munanga 1999; Nascimento 1978). This discourse, in fact, was in line with the views of the Paulista elites of the previous period, as evident in Duarte's 1947 newspaper article. It defined all non-whites as negro (Black), including all those who defined themselves or were defined in the censuses as *pardo* (brown) or *preto* (black), who were forming resistance movements, whether fighting in political opposition to the dictatorship or fighting against racism and colonialism.

This binary approach was reflected in the reintroduction of the color question in the 1980 census, a move facilitated by the declining legitimacy of the military regime and the lobbying of demographers, sociologists, and economists (Nobles 2000). Quantitative studies using census data, from the 1980s onward, showed unequivocally that racial discrimination played an important role in causing social inequalities between whites and non-whites (negros) in Brazil. The growing dominance of a binary classification was evident in the way academics and Black activists together lobbied to prevent a moreno color category from being introduced into the census. This color category was proposed by some anthropologists (Harris et al. 1993) who argued that it was spontaneously claimed by about one-third

of the Brazilian population—as statistics later confirmed (Gois 2008; Turra, Venturi, and Datafolha 1995). In addition, from the 1970s, Indigenous groups found allies in anthropologists and international organizations in campaigning for the census to recognize their Indigenous ethnicity, in spite of their biological miscegenation and the loss of integrity of their ancestral customs (Pacheco de Oliveira 2016), a demand that was finally accepted in the 1991 census.

According to Munanga (1999, 124), Brazilian anti-racism was no longer assimilationist but increasingly differentialist. In the former mode, anti-racist discourse denies the existence of races and seeks the assimilation of all individuals to the mestizo nation. In contrast, differentialist anti-racism affirms the equality of diverse races and ethnicities in the social and political life of the nation (Taguieff 2001).

In sum, in the mid-1960s, various factors destabilized mestizo national narratives in Latin America as a whole, at the same time as authoritarian regimes tried to reinforce such narratives in the context of the Cold War, which created favorable environments for the establishment of civil-military dictatorships. In Brazil, large popular sectors mobilized, in the countryside and in cities, raising fears among the ruling groups of socialist or communist regimes. Many of the peasants' and workers' claims, which figured on the public scene as class discourses, gradually adopted elements drawn from the claims of the Indigenous peasantry and the Black middle class, which foregrounded the struggle against racial inequalities and everyday racism. Meanwhile, the US Black civil rights movement, decolonial struggles in Portuguese Africa, and the fight against South African apartheid provided enormous opportunities for international solidarity and the expansion of anti-racist repertoires. In this context, Brazilian racial democracy paradoxically entered its golden years, being promoted by the Brazilian state as an official diplomatic discourse, while being denounced in international forums by Black and Indigenous social movements as an ideology of racial oppression. Internationally, multiculturalism and multiracialism had become ideals of democratic political coexistence, burying the former ideal of racially and culturally homogeneous nation building.

ANTI-RACIST POLICIES IN BRAZIL IN THE TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY

A milestone in the anti-racist struggle in Brazil was the 1988 Constitution, which made racism a non-bailable offence and recognized the property rights of *quilombola* populations to the ancestral sites on which they lived.[6] These provisions were followed by the adoption of legislation criminalizing racism and establishing protocols for the state recognition of Quilombola

lands. Advocacy services were set up to support victims of racial discrimination and bring their cases to court, and a structure of police stations specializing in racial crimes was established. At the ideological level, Black movements centered on three points: (1) denouncing the narrative of the mestizo nation and racial democracy as fallacious and as reinforcing white supremacy; (2) forming a Black racial group that included as negro all those who, in terms of administrative statistics, classified themselves or were classified as pardo or preto; (3) demanding that the Brazilian state follow the recommendation, made in 1990 by the UN Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, that ethnic identity in the member countries should be defined only by self-declaration.

A second milestone in the anti-racist struggle was the 2001 World Conference against Racism in Durban. Brazil's preparations for the conference spurred demands for affirmative action, and from 2002 Black movements were decisive in the creation of quotas for Black people in several federal and state public universities. Between 2002 and 2012, seventy-one public universities adopted some form of quotas for Black and Indigenous people and Quilombolas. The creation of employment quotas in the public sector was timid, however. Another product of the Durban Conference was Law 10639/03 of 2003, amended by Law 11645/08 of 2008, which made the teaching of Afro-Brazilian, African, and Indigenous history and culture compulsory in public and private schools.

The third milestone was the 2012 decision of the Federal Supreme Court that confirmed the constitutionality of quotas for Black applicants in public universities. This decision led to further laws and regulations strengthening the privileged access of Black people to public universities and to public sector employment at the federal, state, and municipal levels. This move consolidated an anti-racist strategy based on promoting upward mobility for minorities. The implementation of this legislation was accompanied by restrictions in the criteria defining who could benefit from such legislation—that is, who the Brazilian state would recognize as Black, Indigenous, and Quilombola. According to the Federal Supreme Court, negros should be defined principally by phenotypical characteristics as seen by observers (Guimarães 2018). In the case of Indigenous and Quilombola people, discussions are ongoing as to whether land claims should be allowed only for groups effectively occupying their lands when the 1988 Constitution was promulgated.

In an institutional framework favorable to anti-racist struggles, claims of other minority groups—such as LGBTQ people—flourished at the same time. However, these advances have provoked a moral backlash against antidiscrimination initiatives. Whether through evangelical churches and the Catholic Church, regionalist groups dissatisfied with large-scale internal

migrations, groups that combat crime and drug trafficking, groups intent on pushing the agricultural frontier into Indigenous or Quilombola lands, or public opinion that feels coerced by "political correctness," the fact is that new forms of racism have surfaced. A wave of discrimination and prejudice of a regionalist, sexist, and racist nature and of public opinion challenging "human rights" has emerged in Brazil in recent years. The 2018 election of far-right-winger Jair Bolsonaro as president embodied this trend and represents a huge threat to the anti-racist institutional structures created over the last forty years.

THE NARRATIVE OF THE MESTIZO NATION IN COLOMBIA

In Colombia, the idea of mestizaje is a "foundational fiction" in the national imaginary (Sommer 1991). Colonial and postcolonial processes of mestizaje meant that "color, like memory, was a malleable category in everyday life and was defined according to the situation" (Hering Torres 2010, 144). On the other hand, the "habitus of whiteness" (Castro-Gómez 2005) informed practices of distinction and processes that concentrated all forms of capital in the colonial ruling classes. These practices and processes continued into the new republic, despite its egalitarian and integrationist rhetoric, and mestizaje became an ideology of national identity based on a racialized hierarchy that justified the dominance of "white" people, despite being in contradiction to the model of citizenship that was intended to legitimize Republican political power.

From then on, the formation of national sentiment faced a dilemma: how to make the manifestly mixed character of the Colombian population compatible with the clearly white connotations of progress and modernity. The solution to the dilemma was to welcome the models of modernity from Europe and the United States and add, in different ways, the ingredient of racial mixing "in order to provide a distinctly Latin American response to the dilemma" (Wade 1993, 11). Once legal differences were eliminated, racial categories became more fluid and mestizaje began to be valued as a characteristic of the new nation and as a natural attribute or the result of a personal project (Moreno Figueroa 2012). However, the idea of whitening persisted as a promise of inclusion in the community of citizens not only through the exercise of voting rights but also through marriages with "whiter" people, by participation in various political and public spaces, and by adaptation to values of respectability and honor associated with groups seen as white.

In the Colombian case, between 1930 and 1950, representations of mestizaje by Colombian elites fluctuated between a Mexican model that

conceived of mestizaje as the foundation of nationality and an emblem of democracy and an Argentine or southern Brazilian model that sought to progressively eliminate the Black and Indigenous presence, considered as an element of backwardness. Egalitarian rhetoric aside, in Colombia mestizaje has historically represented a whitening project whose objective has been the elimination of Black and Indigenous minorities through their progressive merging into the "superior" white element (Rojas 2002; Wade 1993). The model also envisaged the assimilation of certain elements of Indigenous and Black groups, perceived to be of general or artistic value, but always as part of an overarching process of biological and cultural whitening, understood as progress. Although the project of whitening (through European immigration) largely failed in practice, the ideology of mestizaje retained great influence until the end of the twentieth century.

As a racial order, Colombia is distinctive in relation to many other Latin American societies because of the presence of two significant subaltern population groups, Indigenous and Black. According to the 2005 census, Afro-Colombians are 10.6 percent of the total population and Indigenous peoples 3.45 percent. There are 120 different Indigenous peoples, of which 70 percent live in *resguardos* or reserves. Survey data indicate that people identifying as white represent 30 percent of the total, which implies that 56 percent of the population might identify as mestizo (Telles and Paschel 2014).

Although Black and Indigenous populations have always been the object of racism, there are differences between them in terms of the dynamics of insertion into national configurations of modernity (Urrea Giraldo, Viáfara López, and Viveros Vigoya 2014). While Black people did not occupy a place in the official structures of society or in academic thinking after the colonial period, Indigenous groups have had a socially accepted status, albeit as an exotic vestige. For a long time, the indio embodied the symbolic otherness in relation to which national identity was constructed. Meanwhile, Black individuals were excluded from the foundational narrative of national identity and were denied a distinctive status, while also being socially included as ordinary citizens. They were recognized as members of a devalued social group but also as people with strictly individual possibilities of social mobility, which prevented them from building an ethnic-racial identity that could be used politically.

In Colombian society, the concept of race has been different from that prevailing in the Anglo-Saxon world, where it is defined in terms of fixed borders and ancestral marks detected by institutionalized systems (e.g., "the one drop of blood rule"). In Colombia, racialization manifests itself by incorporating socioeconomic differences into a pigmentocratic game. Despite the fact that, since the Republican period, individual education

and upward mobility have gained importance in ethnic-racial categorization (Solano and Flórez Bolívar 2011, 23–68), skin color has continued to be a significant factor, associated not only with people's socioeconomic and political position but also with their behavior, character, and customs. Thus classes have (skin) colors, in the sense that, generally speaking, people with greater capital (social, cultural, economic, symbolic, etc.) are "lighter" in appearance, while those with less capital are "darker" (which implies that darker mestizos may also be victims of racism).

For these historical reasons, the racial discrimination to which Afro-Colombians, Indigenous people, and darker mestizos have been subjected has also been social class discrimination. Racial boundaries between the different classes have partially blurred, due to the dynamics of mestizaje. However, their persistence has been guaranteed through mechanisms of social exclusion and cultural discrimination, characteristic of pigmentocracies, which have allowed the elites to reproduce themselves as a mainly "white" group. Skin color and hair texture remain phenotypic features that allow the classification and ranking of populations, subjecting subaltern groups to subordination by virtue of their race, ethnicity, class, and gender (Urrea Giraldo, Viáfara López, and Viveros Vigoya 2014). However, the idea has persisted that the social inequalities that characterize the country are fundamentally a class problem, without any consideration of the connections that exist between race and class (Telles and Project on Ethnicity and Race in Latin America 2014).

THE CRISIS OF THE COLOMBIAN MESTIZO NATION AND THE CHALLENGES OF MULTICULTURALISM

With the new constitution of 1991, the image of Colombia as mestizo was replaced, at least in political discourse, by the recognition of the nation as "pluriethnic and multicultural." Indigenous and Black movements played an important role in challenging the ideology of mestizaje and forcing multiculturalism onto the Colombian political landscape. Indigenous movements emerged from the Andean region of the country during the first decades of the twentieth century and were expressed through rebellions such as the one led by Manuel Quintín Lame, between 1914 and 1918. In the 1940s, influenced by the Mexican Revolution, intellectual and political tendencies of indigenismo were strengthened until they lost some influence under a succession of conservative governments. From the 1960s, indigenismo was revived by the founding of the first anthropology departments in Colombia and of special units for Indigenous affairs within the Colombian Institute of Agrarian Reform (INCORA). At the same time the Indige-

nous movement was strengthened by a growing struggle for ethnic and land rights. The Indigenous movement played a decisive role in the 1991 Constituent Assembly (Castillo 2007) and subsequent legislative developments, as well as in rural and urban social mobilizations more widely (e.g., during the Uribe Vélez government, 2002–2010).

The issue of racism did not appear explicitly in the first attempts at organizing Black people in the 1940s (the Club Negro and the Centro de Estudios Afrocolombianos), or in the parliamentary activity of several of the protagonists of these initiatives. Nevertheless, their proposals for equality between social and regional groups was simultaneously, albeit mostly implicitly, a search for equality between racial groups, in the terms authorized by the national context of that time (Pisano 2012). From the 1970s, however, some social organizations began to recognize racism as a problem that operates in everyday interactions, institutions, and society. In 1976, the Soweto Circle of Studies was founded in Pereira, led by Juan de Dios Mosquera. This was the precursor for the Movimiento Nacional Cimarrón, born in 1982, influenced by the African American civil rights movement and the anti-colonial and anti-apartheid movements in Africa (Agudelo 2005). This group still exists and focuses on denouncing racial discrimination and lobbying the government for measures to eradicate it.

By 1985, a second wave of Afro-Colombian organizations arose, this time related to ethnic-territorial and environmental issues in Colombia's Pacific region (Agudelo 2005; Castillo 2007; Wade 1995). From that moment, Colombia's Black movement has been marked by a tension between ethnic or cultural claims, mostly based on the Pacific region, and racial claims, based on the national level. Over time these two sets of claims have converged, as organizations that make ethnic demands have accepted the need to incorporate racial categories into the production of national statistics and into quantitative or qualitative studies of racial discrimination. Several national-level organizations have emerged, and the number and variety of Afro-Colombian organizations have increased considerably—but in a dispersed and discontinuous manner. Only a few have had the capacity to access state resources or international cooperation.

Overall, there is still a big gap between the advances represented by the so-called Inclusive 1991 Constitution and the incorporation of these transformations into the daily practices of state officials and citizens. First, the older assimilationist model has not been fully displaced. Second, differences between the Indigenous population (as a political and legal category) and the Afro-Colombian population (devoid of any particular legal characterization) have persisted and were reflected in the differential recognition of rights in the new constitution, which gave rise to multiple laws for Indigenous people and a relative lack of legislation for Afro-Colombians.

Also since 1991, the Black movement, like the Indigenous one, has faced the challenge of statistical visibility vis-à-vis the state, civil society, and other social actors, oscillating between an emphasis on ethnicity or culture and race or phenotype. While Indigenous people lobby for recognition in exclusively cultural terms, racialized phenotypic criteria affect Afro-Colombian identification more strongly than for Indigenous groups or the dark-skinned mestizo population (Urrea Giraldo, Viáfara López, and Viveros Vigoya 2014). It is often assumed that Indigenous peoples suffer less racism than Black populations, and the former tend to talk in terms of economic, cultural, and linguistic discrimination rather than referring explicitly to racism. However, it is important to consider the interrelationships between territorial dispossession and structural racism guiding the processes of accumulation of land and resources that displace Indigenous communities.

Despite the changes brought by multiculturalism, racial categories continue to operate in everyday interactions, although they have gradually been replaced by a discourse of ethnicity and culture, thus legitimizing and normalizing practices of racism, as has occurred in the rest of Latin America (De la Cadena 2001). The new urban Black generations have internalized the ambiguities of the Colombian socio-racial order, but unlike previous generations, they have benefited from the legitimacy that multiculturalist discourse gives to Black cultural activism. However, they continue to face familiar difficulties in making themselves recognized outside the cultural realm, and even within the cultural realm, without making recourse to the body, as if culture and the body were ultimately the only forms of capital available to them (Viveros Vigoya 2005).

The hopeful multiculturalist environment of the 1990s was accompanied by a progressive deterioration of the political situation in the regions, the weakening of the presence of the state, the worsening of the armed conflict in humanitarian terms, and its expansion to new areas, including the Pacific coast and the Black communities located there. The intensification of the armed conflict in the Pacific region has hindered the communities' processes of autonomous territorial development and has led to the mass displacement of populations (Meertens, Viveros Vigoya, and Arango 2008). The arrival of these Black people in the big cities, particularly Bogotá, has had enormous effects in terms of making their existence and their problems visible, no longer only in remote regions but now also in the political heart of the nation. The massive presence of displaced Black people in the capital has brought to light the workings of different forms of racism, as these people were forced into a new inflection of the intersection between Blackness and poverty: being poor, Black, and displaced. These categories tend to overlap in everyday experiences and in social identifications based on skin color (Cunin 2003).

THE CONSTRUCTION OF ANTI-RACIST POLICIES IN COLOMBIA

In Colombia there have been legislative advances since the year 2000, including the enactment of laws that prohibit any type of discrimination including racial discrimination. Nevertheless, it has still been difficult to talk openly about racism and to transcend the recognition of cultural diversity, reflected in the multiculturalism of the 1990s. There is still a long way to go for both the state and social movements in designing anti-racist policies that confront, erode, or eradicate the complex social inequalities caused by racism.

In Colombia, the simple recognition of racism is hampered by everyday tactics of denial or minimization. Everyday expressions of racism are rarely spectacular, and racial discrimination is practiced at the individual level, as a form of exclusion rather than aggression. Those who dare to denounce racism are subject to tactics of delegitimization, in which they are themselves accused of being racist, of having a "complex," or of being resentful. In the public sector, there is resistance to including an ethnic-racial dimension in the formulation of policy, on the grounds that differentiating users by categories of this type will introduce a discriminatory criterion. Any allusion to the racial is met with a defensive attitude that should be read as an implicit denial of the role state policies play in the reproduction of racism by facilitating hierarchical relations between ethnic-racial groups. It is difficult to recognize the benefits that racism brings to people racialized as white and mestizo, and in this environment it is an arduous task to ensure compliance with affirmative actions, territorial restitution processes, and laws and decrees that guarantee the rights of and reparations for Black and Indigenous populations.

We must also take into account the budget cuts that systematically affect the institutions that provide social welfare and the growing neoliberalization of the logic with which social security is delivered, more focused on individuals and their interactions than on society and social relations. Institutions' scope of action is reduced, and much frustration is generated by growing social polarization and increased displacement. For this reason, many institutions have reformulated their professional practices, aiming to promote users' human development and self-esteem and thus also to increase their capacity to appropriate their rights.

Despite these obstacles, there has been a gradual turn toward anti-racism in the region. By demonstrating the racial inequality and the racism that affect Black and Indigenous peoples, this new turn challenges—but does not displace—powerful ideologies of mestizaje and multiculturalism.

In the Colombian case, many anti-racist actions have been financed by international cooperation agencies, which promote anti-discriminatory programs within the framework of Colombia's Peace Process. The anti-racist actions developed include census-based and statistical studies demonstrating correlations between "race" (mainly defined as skin color), ethnicity, mobility, and social exclusion; affirmative actions and programs of inclusion of Black and Indigenous populations in the educational and labor fields; the implementation of laws that criminalize racial discrimination and some use of these laws to denounce racism; media campaigns in public and private media, and through social media, denouncing racism; and artistic and aesthetic interventions aimed at the visibility and empowerment of Black and Indigenous peoples.

THE NARRATIVE OF THE MESTIZO NATION IN ECUADOR

The Ecuadorian narrative of national formation invokes some key historical facts, which became central elements of national identity, nurturing the mestizo narrative from 1830 until the middle of the twentieth century. The first element is common among Latin American nations that can boast a "glorious" Indigenous past, but in the case of Ecuador the reference is not to the Inca empire, which dominated the northern Andes for only forty years but, rather, to the pre-Hispanic kingdoms that populated today's Ecuador, especially the Kingdom of Quito as studied by the Jesuit Juan de Velasco (1727–1792). As usual, this indigenist historical memory validates a mythical Indigenous past based on "dead Indians," erasing the ongoing subordination and exploitation of the "living Indians."

A second element is the historical claim that Ecuador "is, was, and always will be an Amazonian country," which links it, in a different way, to Indigeneity. The claim is partly a result of the continuous territorial and border disputes and wars that Ecuador has maintained with its neighbors Colombia and, especially, Peru with whom a peace treaty resolving the matter of their Amazonian border was signed as late as 1998. These elements of indigenism were validated by the broader narrative of indigenismo as a public policy in Latin America, which was developed especially in Mexico and Peru from the 1920s onward. In Ecuador, although there were indigenist thinkers, the state did not develop its own indigenist policies and institutions and only half-heartedly supported the temporary development of an indigenist development program funded by international cooperation.

A third element balances Indigeneity with European influences in a way that is typical of indigenismo's underlying goal of assimilating present-day Indigenous populations into the mestizo nation. The name Ecuador

originated with the French and Spanish geographical missions that measured the equator at the end of the eighteenth century; this European recognition was welcomed by the white-mestizo criollo elite as an affirmation of their European roots.[7] The name of Quito was ruled out as a contender for the name of the country, because of its Indigenous ancestry. Paradoxically, however, things equatorial have also been identified with Blackness, because of the relationship with equatorial Africa (Radcliffe and Westwood 1996).

The dominance of the white-mestizo element in the national imaginary was maintained by a policy of "population administration and ventriloquism" (Guerrero 2010), deployed by the Ecuadorian state, from the beginning of the republic until the reforms of the 1960s. Andrés Guerrero argues that the state could not officially recognize the existence of ethnic domination, since it was formally committed to citizen equality, but reproduced it through ventriloquism—that is, speaking for the Indigenous peoples and representing them in the predominantly mestizo national power structure. In Ecuador, a Brazil-style discourse of racial democracy has not been evident. Instead the dominant image is of a mainly mestizo nation into which Indigenous and Black people—who each currently form 7 percent of the total population—should be integrated.

The national narrative relegated Afro-descendant people to invisibility, both during the colonial period and at the beginning of Ecuador's statehood, with an exception made for the well-known formation of the so-called Republic of Zambos in today's province of Esmeraldas. Led by Alonso de Illescas between 1560 and 1622, a group of freed and shipwrecked slaves established a regime that was free from colonial government control, in an interethnic territory where they lived alongside Indigenous people. Leaders of the republic managed to negotiate an agreement with the Spanish in Quito and were depicted in a famous painting, *Los tres mulatos de Esmeraldas* (1599), currently in Spain's Museo del Prado. The partial autonomy thus established was, at the beginning of the nineteenth century, the basis from which the freed Black populations of the gold mines of northern Esmeraldas (Santiago River basin) managed to buy the land where they had always lived (Minda 2015). These ancestral territories later became subject to the extractive pressures of logging, oil-palm, and mining companies.

THE CRISIS OF THE MESTIZO NATION IN ECUADOR

From 1960, Ecuador, like many regions of Latin America, began to feel the influence of the emergence of liberation theology in the Catholic Church and the emergence of new social movements mobilizing around issues of

ethnicity, race, the environment, and human rights. Divisions around social class ceded ground to new forms of participation and political mobilization. It was the height of the Cold War and the emergence of military dictatorships in the Southern Cone. Ecuador lived through two military dictatorships (from 1963 to 1966 and from 1976 to 1979), although these have been characterized as *dictablandas* (soft dictatorships) and one of them was even "revolutionary." Under the first, an agrarian reform process was put into action, which mobilized Indigenous and non-Indigenous farmers in the struggle for land. As in much of Latin America, Ecuador entered a new phase characterized by incorporation into a neoliberal economy driven mainly by oil exports and other forms of extractivism (the extraction and commercialization of primary natural resources).

An Afro-Ecuadorian movement became increasingly visible as a social and political actor, spurred by the US civil rights movement and the liberation struggle of African states against European colonialism. The movement's main agenda was the fight against racial discrimination and ethnic and cultural exclusion. In 1966 Ecuador ratified the UN International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination. This was a strategic moment, as the mestizo-indigenist narrative that dominated the national imaginary began to be questioned by multiculturalist approaches, challenging the conception of the racially and culturally homogeneous nation and providing one of the bases for a return to democracy in the early 1980s.

THE CONSTRUCTION OF ANTI-RACIST POLICIES IN ECUADOR

Two important events occurred in the last decade of the twentieth century. The first was the Indigenous uprising of 1990, which was followed by a series of mobilizations that transformed Indigenous peoples from social actors to political actors with their own voice. The second was the approval of the 1998 Constitution, in which the Ecuadorian nation was defined as multicultural and multiethnic, an unprecedented fact in Republican life, as the constitution recognized for the first time the collective rights of Indigenous and Afro-Ecuadorian peoples and nationalities, including rights relating to the recognition of territories, languages, and identity.

With the beginning of the twenty-first century, the country faced a serious economic crisis characterized by bankruptcy and the adoption of a dollarized economy. Neoliberal economic adjustment policies generated important processes of protest and mobilization of the main social actors affected by these measures. The mobilization of different social actors—Indigenous peoples, Afro-Ecuadorians, environmentalists, women, workers,

human rights defenders—led to the convening of a new Constituent Assembly in 2008, which resulted in the approval of a revised constitution.

The cumulative effects of struggles from the early 1980s and the new constitutional norms shaped the construction of anti-racist policies. The main legislative changes were (1) the legal recognition of the collective territories of Indigenous and Afro-Ecuadorian peoples and nationalities; (2) the definition of the Ecuadorian nation as plurinational and intercultural;[8] (3) the approval of the right to historical reparation of Indigenous and Afro-Ecuadorian peoples and nationalities; (4) the approval of a plan to combat racism and ethnic and cultural exclusion, through decree 60 (2009), which specified policies to improve access to education, health, housing, and employment for Indigenous and Afro-Ecuadorian peoples; (5) the approval in 2014 of a criminal code that, for the first time, allowed for the prosecution of racial hate crimes; (6) the officialization of intercultural bilingual education in primary and high schools; and (7) the establishment of legal pluralism, recognizing the Indigenous justice system alongside the ordinary justice system. In addition, the 2008 Constitution recognized rights in favor of other groups that were classed as historically discriminated against, including children, adolescents, senior citizens, women, people with disabilities, and LGBTIQ+ people, among others. All this normative recognition gave rise to what João Pacheco de Oliveira (2016, 34) calls an epiphany of alterities.

However, all these transformations have not been enough to overcome practices of racial discrimination in the country. Legal norms are insufficient, and it is necessary to put in place anti-racist and both medium- and long-term social equality policies including affirmative action initiatives. This type of policy can address the structural racism that is evident in the limited participation of Indigenous and Afro-Ecuadorian people in political positions at the national, regional, and local levels and in higher education, including high level academic and administrative positions in universities.

A balance sheet of the constitution of 2008, ten years after its approval, shows more setbacks than advances. The government of Rafael Correa (2007–2017) was an exercise in affirming the multicultural (but still fundamentally mestizo) character of the nation instead of constructing a fully plurinational and intercultural narrative. The government's repeated use of the discourse of *buen vivir* (good living)—or *alli kawsay* in Kichwa—did little more than empty this Indigenous cosmological expression of its content, thus reestablishing an assimilationist and whitening narrative of the nation, to the detriment of the construction of a state that is truly plurinational and intercultural, more egalitarian and equitable, and less racist and discriminatory.

CONCLUSION

These narratives of mestizaje show there are important variations within what is sometimes seen (especially when making comparisons with the United States) as a "Latin American" variant of race relations (Warren and Sue 2011). What stands out is the variegated yet recognizable figure of the mestizo—the mestizo character of all four countries creates similar problems for anti-racism. First, although racism is much more of a public issue in Brazil than in the other three countries, even in Brazil we can observe the classic tendency of a mestizo society to minimize and even deny the relevance of racism by making reference to mixedness and the tolerance it supposedly generates. Second, the history of these countries has created a powerful link between leaving the land, urbanization, and becoming mestizo. This gives particular significance to Indigenous (and Black) struggles for land and territory but also makes it hard to create a conceptual space for urban Indigeneity. Third, anti-racism in all four countries faces the fact that becoming mestizo has often been a story of upward mobility and, above all in national mythologies of modernization and progress, has been strongly associated with whiteness. A key challenge for anti-racism in this context is to break that association and create a legitimate space for Blackness and Indigeneity that is not associated with poverty and backwardness. It is worth exploring in depth the strategies that Black and Indigenous organizations are pursuing in the context of these mestizo racial formations, the strengths of different strategies, and the particular challenges they face.